

Vietnam was divided into two territories along the 17th Parallel in 1954. The area around this division was technically a demilitarized zone (DMZ), although in practice it saw its fair share of military action. Today, visitors to the DMZ can see the Rock Pile, which was used as a US Marine Corps lookout and artillery base, and the remains of Camp Carroll—a base from 1966 to 1972. Day trips to the area go past the Rock Pile, McNamara Line, Khe Sanh, and Hamburger Hill.

Guides into DMZ territory mostly operate from the former US Marine post at Dong Ha; going into this territory without a guide is not recommended, due to the amount of unexploded ordnance that remains there, unmarked.

Hien Luong Bridge and Ben Hai River Museum

Destroyed in 1967, the original Hien Luong Bridge marked the division of Vietnam along the 17th Parallel. It was made from iron and wood and painted half red and half yellow to acknowledge this physical and ideological boundary. The bridge was rebuilt according to its original specifications in the early 21st century, but painted blue and yellow to symbolize Vietnam's reunification. The bridge is now flanked by the Unified Memorial of Hope on the south bank of the Ben Hai River and a colossal flagpole, border guard monument, and history museum on the north side.

Khe Sanh Museum

This base near the DMZ was a major target of the NVA's Tet Offensive, with US troops besieged there under heavy artillery fire. The Khe Sanh Museum commemorates the battle with a reconstruction of an American bunker, as well as vehicles, helicopters, weapons, and other objects.

Truong Son Cemetery

This hillside cemetery was built for those who died on the Ho Chi Minh Trail—the major supply route from the North to the South—which was known to them as the Truong Son Trail. The cemetery is home to around 10,000 graves, which is only two-fifths of the total number of people who died on the trail.

Vinh Moc Tunnels

An entire coastal hamlet sought refuge inside these tunnels during the Vietnam War, sometimes for days or weeks at a time. The residents built their three-level subterranean village deep underground to avoid US bombs, which were capable of burrowing 30 feet (10 m) underground. In addition to living quarters, the tunnels featured a hospital, kitchens, storage areas, and a large hall for community gatherings. More spacious than the Cu Chi tunnels, Vinh Moc offers guided tours to visitors.

THUA THIEN-HUE

Ho Chi Minh Museum, Hue

Hue's museum focuses on the schooling of the revolutionary leader, who studied here from 1895–1901 and 1906–09.

Hue Citadel

A major target of the 1968 Tet Offensive, the imperial city of Hue bears the scars of battle. While some of the buildings have been destroyed, the northern sector in particular is riddled with bullet holes and crumbling walls.

HO CHI MINH TRAIL

Tracing the trail